

SUMMARY



Peter Senge's

THE FIFTH DISCIPLINE

*The Art & Practice of
The Learning Organization*

CRUSH THE BOOK
IN 20 MINUTES

ANT HIVE MEDIA

Peter Senge's

The Fifth Discipline

The Art & Practice of The Learning Organization

Summary by Ant Hive Media



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INTRODUCTION

Since Peter Senge is a follower of 'Systems Thinking', he states that because people work in tandem with things, the ecosystems survive. He acknowledges that since people have been working together, communities have survived and if they wouldn't have, communities would have disappeared. By developing 'learning organization' concept for a workforce, Peter Senge utilizes the method of systems thinking to facilitate the companies to have more success. In a learning organization, a community of the total workforce is created and the team members learn together and share their opinions. This creates thinking that is interconnected bringing them on a similar wavelength. It promotes more openness, productivity and communication through shared and organized learning resulting in more progress of the team.

The book presents the thoughts and ideas of Senge in a concise manner. It states the basic five disciplines that are essential for the members of a learning organization and each of these disciplines are equally important. It promulgates the notion that in case of team learning, a greater synergized knowledge is created as compared to individual and disconnected learning since it aims at developing shared perspectives and eliminates egos. It enables business organizations to have a broader perspective and resolve long-term issues rather than focusing on short-term solutions

The Fifth Discipline, since its first publication in the year 1990, has been an inspiration to several organizations that have recognized worth of the ideas of Senge. The concept is over 20 years old but is still discussed in the world of business. Managers whose businesses have faced problems due to learning paralysis as well as repetitive mistakes have sought inspiration and guidance from The Fifth Discipline. The book has been used by the companies to increase the speed of growth at both business and personal level. The book has achieved the status of a handbook for leaders and the second edition of the book published in 2006 exemplifies the growing importance and popularity in a dynamic business environment.

MAIN IDEA

Since business evolves consistently, it is imperative that we continue learning to have competitive edge. Those organizations that emphasize on learning stay ahead of competition and are more successful. For implementing new techniques, ideas and methods it is important to identify the mistakes that we are making.

Learning should not only be limited as a personal practice but we should rather promote it within our own organizations while not just encouraging it but rather enhancing it. The learning organizations must be used as platforms to solve bigger problems through encouragement of communal values which refer to a united workforce with similar visions and through evaluating the structures that underlay and support attainment of results that we seek.

It is clearer now that those businesses where learning is one of the core functions of their workforce are more successful. Businesses are constituted of individuals who form a collective. The aggregate of the collective's knowledge and experience enable organizations to achieve greater success. Businesses that are able to maximize and optimize the talents and abilities of the individuals while facilitating their assimilation into a single collective are more successful.

BOOK SECTION OVERVIEW

SECTION ONE

The Competitive Advantages of Learning

The world of business has cut-throat competition and to survive, it is important that organizations learn to be flexible, must be adaptive and should possess a greater level of ingenuity. Learning organizations nurture flexibility, ingenuity, ability to innovate and think ahead and also the ability to adapt to newer systems. Although this concept sounds simpler than it is, a remarkably large number of organizations fail in making optimum use of the learning practices. Very often, businesses attempt to thrive only on basis of their intuition. However, experience and knowledge form the foundation for intuition and higher the level of experience and knowledge, better is the intuitive ability for solving problems.

SECTION TWO

The Five Core Disciplines of Learning Organizations

Mastering the five basic disciplines is important for learning organizations:

1. Personal Mastery

Ability to master the energy, focus and patience of oneself results in a well-rounded person who is of great significance for an organization.

2. Mental Models

Our decision making is influenced by our understanding of our prejudiced perceptions and ingrained mentality.

3. Building Shared Visions

A vision shared by the team regarding the future of the company is more beneficial as compared to disconnected visions promulgated by employees who are obsessed with themselves.

4. Team Learning

A powerful and fulfilling collective is created by the combined expertise and knowledge brought together by team work.

5. Systems Thinking

Systems thinking' enables companies to focus on the larger picture and provides them with long-term solutions that are more sustainable than short-term solutions to the inherent problems.

Although it is possible that these disciplines can be learned individually, it is more beneficial to see them as a whole. For instance, Systems thinking, the last of the five disciplines is fulcrum and moving forward without it is similar to starting the car that has wrong engine.

SECTION THREE

The Key Challenges, Practical Problems and Issues Learning Organizations Face

Consider that a learning organization is an experiment and follows a process based on trial and error. When problems are presented, new lessons are learnt while trying to overcome them. Facing problems is inevitable for a business and learning organizations help prepare for the problems by practically testing them even before they occur.

General problems that a company faces includes:

- Internal politics
- Exclusive power
- Insufficient time for learning
- Inability to maintain a decent work and life balance
- Repeated mistakes
- Difficulties with leading and organization that is a learning organization

Overcoming these issues is critical for an organization. Still unbelievably several companies are yet to identify feasible solutions for these problems and many companies have completely failed to address these issues. The very basic nature of the learning organization is to present these issues thereby facilitating the finding of a solution. Learning organization supports the admission of the fact that problems do exist. Problems may not be clearly visible for a while but ultimately they will surface and cause damage. A learning organization's job is to ensure that we are prepared when the problems surface.

BOOK SECTION DETAILS

SECTION ONE

THE COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGES OF LEARNING

MAIN IDEA

Businesses are affected by the external changes. When, outside of a company parameters change, the effects of such changes can cascade into a disaster if the organization is unable to positively respond to changes. The problems may even worsen if the organizations are not able to understand what changes are taking place around them. The ability for adapting to critical changes and responding to them is nurtured by the learning organization. Above all, it teaches the requirement for being prepared when the disaster strikes.

SUPPORTING IDEAS

Due to its ability to learn, a learning organization is a step ahead as compared to other organizations. Several organizations fall short for the following reasons:

Employees become stagnant. They are scared of change since their positive has become their identity. A learning organization promoted versatility and helps identify employees by determining their well-rounded abilities and the number of functions that they are capable of performing.

It may be termed as loyalty or conceit, but generally whenever a company faces a tumultuous situation, it is attributed to the competition instead of the own performance of the company. This is however misguided and not conducive for change. Bad habits are a result of our failure to acknowledge the mistakes made by us.

Generally businesses react to consequences when an event occurs, for example reduced revenue instead of rooting out the primary cause of the

situation. It is important to look at larger picture. By focusing on the effect, its reoccurrence is being encouraged. For instance, a doctor who diagnoses a patient with headache will try to identify the root cause rather than giving a few pills to the patient and sending them away.

Due to their ingrained habits, a non-learning organization is unable to see the larger picture. It is like putting the blame on the goalkeeper of the soccer team when a goal is conceded instead of identifying the root causes of the problems that resulted in the goal, like a poor defense. A non-learning organization constantly reacts to consequences of the events and makes themselves handicap. A learning organization identifies the root cause of the problems and presents the solution that eliminates the possibility of the reoccurrence of the problem.

Learning organizations evaluate the behavioral patterns that might result in the arising of the issue. By doing this, they alter the patters and effectively control their own destinies. Alternately, non-learning organizations continue being reactive instead of being proactive and simply put off the things that would continue to come back to haunt them.

A non-learning organization is passive.

A learning organization is active.

More importantly, learning organizations are:

1. Forward Thinking

Mistakes are eliminated by continuous learning.

2. Dynamic

Shared learning and team-work are emphasized.

3. Productive

Since the entire team continues to learn, each of the members is able to optimize the strengths of each other and this leads to higher production

4. Communal

Production and shared knowledge are the key elements. Sharing of talents and continuous communication take the teams forward.

5. Innovative – A learning organization leads by introducing improvements that are genuinely effective.

Quotes - Building Learning Organizations

“Building learning organizations involves developing people who learn to see as systems thinkers see, who develop their personal mastery and who learn how to surface and restructure mental models collaboratively. Given the influence of organizations in today’s world, this may be one of the most powerful steps towards helping us ‘rewrite the code’, altering not just what we think, but our predominant ways of thinking. In this sense, learning organizations may be a tool not just for the evolution of organizations, but for the evolution of intelligence.” - Peter Senge

“Learning disabilities are tragic in children, but they are fatal in organizations. Because of them, few corporations live even half as long as a person - most die before they reach the age of forty.” - Peter Senge

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SECTION TWO

THE FIVE CORE DISCIPLINES OF LEARNING ORGANIZATIONS

MAIN IDEA

The Core Five Disciplines of a Learning Organization:

1. Personal Mastery

Ability to master the energy, focus and patience of oneself results in a well-rounded person who is of great significance for an organization.

2. Mental Models

Our decision making is influenced by our understanding of our prejudiced perceptions and ingrained mentality.

3. Building Shared Visions

A vision shared by the team regarding the future of the company is more beneficial as compared to disconnected visions promulgated by employees who are obsessed with themselves.

4. Team Learning

A powerful and fulfilling collective is created by the combined expertise and knowledge brought together by team work

5. Systems Thinking

Systems thinking' enables companies to focus on the larger picture and provides them with long-term solutions that are more sustainable than short-term solutions to the inherent problems.

SUPPORTING IDEAS

1. Personal Mastery

Ability to master the energy, focus and patience of oneself results in a well-rounded person who is of great significance for an organization.

An organization by itself is intangible and inanimate and exists via the activities and consciousness of the individual members. Therefore, organizations themselves do not learn; rather the individuals who constitute organizations must learn.

Master Personal Mastery:

The problem solving and intellectual growth of individuals are promoted. It facilitates in maturing of a person to make them a well-rounded individual who is capable of bringing greater resolve, intuition, foresight and discipline into their respective organizations.

It helps promoting new skills.

It enables individuals to improve themselves, their peers and organizations.

It leads to a journey that helps achieve various experiences full of advantages.

It embeds within individuals the desire for continuously gathering knowledge and improving oneself in the various facets of life.

These improvements positively impact their professional lives.

Learning organizations are the total and combined knowledge possessed by the individual members. Businesses that promulgate a large volume of learning from each of the members become significantly strong. If knowledge can be considered as power, the combined knowledge of all the members can be considered as mega-power.

There is no end to personal mastery and therefore an individual is constantly urged to learn and by this they are able to achieve greater of the following:

Vision

A person with high level of personal mastery has goals that are clearer and they are capable of envisioning their future more clearly.

Realism

Everyone dreams and some of the dreams are more realistic as compared to others. There is higher chance of these dreams becoming reality by personal mastery. Individuals are taught to be more realistic while also being aided in attainment of their objectives.

Power

Few things are beyond our control and these cannot be changed. However, when it comes to business, everything can be changed. When you start identifying the underlying reasons, you achieve more power. Identifying causes and not just their effects result in empowerment. We are better able to spot errors with personal mastery.

Subconscious

Without sounding Freudian, most of us depend upon our subconscious for resolution of problems. Most of the information that we receive gets stored in the subconscious and though we believe that we have lost significant parts of it over the years, it often surprises us when those memories resurface suddenly whenever we face a problem. It is referred to as intuition. Therefore, our intuition develops more with learning.

The basic flaw that a non-learning organization has is that it does not support the thought that there can be individual personalities that are bold enough to say what is on their mind and challenge status quo. In such organizations, everyone is merely considered as a part of the machinery and they are expected to continue working without questioning anything. A learning organization promotes personality, individuality and also personal mastery. Such organizations promote honest, frank and open work environment that nurtures unique perspectives and encourages innovation.

Quotes - Personal Mastery

“The core leadership strategy is simple; be a model. Commit yourself to your own personal mastery. Talking about personal mastery may open people’s minds somewhat, but actions always speak louder than words. There’s nothing more powerful you can do to encourage others in their quest for personal mastery than to be serious in your own quest.” - Peter Senge

2. Mental Models

Our decision making is influenced by our understanding of our prejudiced perceptions and ingrained mentality.

A major problem with regards to business is the fact we try to perceive its working in the mind and this can stall progress. For instance, while reading a poem, we visualize it in a certain way; however when we read something that is totally different, we discard it for not being a poem, although it could be a totally innovative type of poem.

We have a prejudiced perception when we determine the way an organization must function and it is based on our previous experiences. Altering the existing mindset of an organization must be one of the basic goals and important targets of the learning organizations. Changing the mindsets must precede changing of reality. When you are able to enter someone else's mind, you are better placed to influence the decision making of theirs. However, due to the inherent prejudices, several businesses repeatedly make the same mistakes due to their stubbornness.

Master Mental Models

- Exists in mind
- Resist change
- Affect actions

Create alternatives to change the mental models

A mental model that is cemented does not change easily provided there are no stronger and more feasible alternatives. If someone can be convinced to examine a particular situation in a different manner, they might be motivated to change their mindset.

Create new power in the boardroom.

We look towards a 'higher power' to get inspired and for mental models and knowledge. We try to mimic those from whom we are trying to learn. If a new board of directors with new ideas is appointed, it will motivate the team to reevaluate their existing ideas and preconceptions.

Create self-awareness.

Just a few of us know that we possess mental models. Motivating people to become calculative and considerate and to analyze and reflect upon their

thoughts as to why do they think what they think, they become more aware of the mental models of theirs that exist and this allows them to reform.

Get people to ask questions.

Interactions with others help unearth the mental models that exist and questioning can reveal how the mental models influence our behavior.

Characteristics of learning organizations facilitate becoming aware of our own mental models. This comes as a challenge to us for replacing and improving them and to utilize these models to benefit our organizations. A large number of organizations restrict themselves to barely a few of the mental models; the ones that are at disposal of the employees of the company. Raising an awareness of these helps organizations to develop completely new models that are of advantage to them. Likewise, once a newer mental model is activated in individuals, they are soon replaced by even new mental models. A learning organization facilitates moving ahead and experimenting. They discourage stagnation.

3. Building Shared Visions

A vision shared by the team regarding the future of the company is more beneficial as compared to disconnected visions promulgated by employees who are obsessed with themselves.

Several among us have visions. Learning organizations aim at getting the collective of people to share visions that are common. When all of us are committed towards working for common goals, the result could be outstanding. However, if the visions are disjointed, it will result in conflicts and subsequently to failure. Shared visions are nurtured by each team member and it is worked upon and harnessed by each of the insightful and powerful individuals.

Master Building Shared Visions

Suppressing egos

Whenever there are ego conflicts among individuals, there is no possibility of having a shared vision. Shared visions are not created by competing but rather the idea of everyone must be given due credence and should be heard.

Each of these ideas however must contribute for developing a comprehensive shared vision among the team.

Encourage individuals for sharing their visions

When a larger number of people share their visions, it increases their feeling of worthiness and self-esteem. It fully utilizes their personal strengths and also increases the strength of the entire collective. If individuals feel that they have been left out, it would lead to resentment.

Shared vision should be given space to breathe

It is important to allow shared visions to live their own lives. They must be allowed to gradually grow on their own rather than being influenced by any specific individual. If there are any disagreements, they must be resolved. It will result in improving the life of shared visions.

Govern

Although shared vision requires freedom to grow, it is crucial that it is directed in the right manner to ensure that the momentum is not lost. It can be done by asking questions such as. 'What is being created?', 'what is the ideology?' and 'is the vision aligned with the actual ideals?'

Keep things in check

Although the vision must be allowed to flourish, it must also be kept in check to comply with reality. An unrealistic vision is just overselling oneself.

It is proven by experience that a learning organization is better for development of a shared vision as compared to a non-learning organization. Shared visions are more potent and powerful vis-à-vis personal visions and are made stronger by the synergy of several great minds. It is similar to a skyscraper which grows till it towers over the city and becomes the centerpiece. The shared vision of the learning organizations is similar to the skyscraper that becomes the city's centerpiece, the sum total of the individual expressions.

Quotes – Shared Vision

“When you are immersed in a vision, you know what needs to be done. But you often don’t know how to do it. You run an experiment because you think it’s going to get you there. It doesn’t work. New input. New data. You change direction and run another experiment. Everything is an experiment but there is no ambiguity at all. It’s perfectly clear why you are doing it. People aren’t saying, ‘Give me a guarantee it will work.’ Everybody knows there is no guarantee. But the people are committed nonetheless.” - Ed Simon, CEO, Herman Miller

4. Team Learning

A powerful and fulfilling collective is created by the combined expertise and knowledge brought together by team work.

There is limitation to what an individual is capable of achieving, especially in a competitive business world. When a synergy of individual learning is created, the combined output is extraordinary. Team learning results in combination and collaboration for pointing the company along with all the assembled and acquired skills towards a particularly clear direction. Consequently, the organization is able to attain all goals much faster.

Team learning process seeks:

- Sharing skills
- Coordination for action
- Developing and nurturing interaction
- Defining one single and clear goal
- Promoting and refining communication
- Taking the business to next level

Master Team Learning:

Creating platforms for an open debate

Learning increases when topics are discussed among the people. When they debate on a point along with their peers, their arguments become more informed and rounded. This exposes the weaknesses and strengths of all those involved which trims off the fat.

Encouraging conflict

Conflict exists at the core of a debate. When people argue, their different perspectives and arguments result in flow of more knowledge, information and leads to enlightenment. Instead of playing down conflict while discussing, it is feasible to embrace it

Creation of learning platforms.

To enhance team learning, one of the good methods is taking the employees off their desks and to an environment that encourages them to learn, bond and discuss.

Team learning is much better than individual learning. Teams that learn together, move forward better and ultimately win as a team. When persons learn as individuals, they form different techniques, ways and ideas as compared to their peers. These differences in vision and style result in slow performance and chaos. Everyone must have the same wavelength and learning as a team promotes shared visions, goals and results in efficiently creating workplace harmony.

5. Systems Thinking

Systems thinking' enables companies to focus on the larger picture and provides them with long-term solutions that are more sustainable than short-term solutions to the inherent problems.

It is to be noted that the title of the book is The Fifth Discipline. The last and fifth discipline is Systems Thinking and is the fulcrum. The first 4 disciplines will fail without this discipline. These five principles are complementary and are individual parts of a whole. They are like a car that will struggle to efficiently perform efficiently if a major component of the car is missing. Systems Thinking is like the engine of the car and it acts as the force that drives the performance.

We are encouraged by systems thinking to look at the entire picture instead of few snapshots. It promotes people to identify patterns that affect their performance and helps them analyze these factors to stem the

improvements. Systems thinking does not merely identify an event's consequence as a quick fix but rather tries to eliminate the cause.

Master Systems Thinking:

Focuses on avoiding long-term problems. Simply focusing on short-term problems and their issues will result in a continuous barrage of them.

The main reason for the poor performance of a company is its system. Therefore, just like you will not push your own body beyond limits for winning a race while also knowing that something is stopping you, you must look carefully for the reasons that result in poor performance of your business. If anything physical holds you back while running on the race track, you must seek the advice for your system if it is slow.

Quick fixes are discouraged by the systems thinking. If you believe that a problem can completely be rooted out just by finding a makeshift and temporary solution, you cannot be farther from truth. It is as pointless as using glass wall for stopping an avalanche.

Shortcuts to finding solutions are discouraged by Systems thinking. Shabby work is a symbol of a shabbily organized company and if one cannot work towards analyzing their systems, it reflects poorly upon the entire business.

It is important to focus on both, the cause and its effect. Several organizations solely focus on effects and ignore causes. It is important to address the causes and the causes of those causes.

To boost the system, even a small amount of challenge is sufficient. For instance, mechanics can easily fix cars because they know what needs to be done and a little tweak can also fix the car. Very often the basic underlying issue in a system is very simple and is easily visible. A learning organization helps in looking at such issues in a more clear and quick manner.

Experience is rewarded by the systems thinking. With more analysis of the system, more quickly the work can be completed and the success rate will

be higher.

Organizations are large entities and similar to a human body, they are constituted of a large network of organs, veins and arteries that are linked to each other. Organizations have a large network of elements that communicate to one another and work together. Hence, while examining the problem, one must not focus only on one part of the organization but instead must focus on the entire organization as well as the other parts.

The purpose of systems thinking process is not to hamper relationships. Pointing fingers on others and blaming them will not contribute positively towards the larger picture. Therefore, blame game must be avoided since it will only hamper the morale of the others and will divert focus from the main issues.

Evaluating Cause and Effect

Cause explains the 'why' factor; the reason for the occurrence of the issue. Examining it helps with explaining why something has gone wrong. You will not be able to provide a long-term and viable solution unless all the factors that led to the issue are considered. Failure to do so will only help find temporary and partial solutions that have negative impact and the issue will persist.

Analyzing the cause enables identifying its root cause. It is possible to destroy Japanese Knotweed if it is uprooted and similarly, a problem can be eliminated by uprooting its cause. This enables you to reach the core of the issue.

Analyzing the root cause of an issue is helpful in actually identifying it. It facilitates not only in eliminating the specific issue, but will also allow you to refine the process for a long time.

Similar to Japanese Knotweed, which is an invasive plant and grows in an unrestricted manner until it is stopped, a problem also functions in a similarly invasive manner. It can lead to:

Unstoppably growth

Adversely affect the growth of the business

The method is simple. It involves finding the underlying issues and eradicating them and this will lead to the growth of the business.

An understanding of the benefits of causes and effects allows looking beyond mere symptoms of the issue and identifying the actual causes of the symptoms. Doctors simply do not extract the cancerous mole from a patient; they try to attack the cause of it. Similarly, you must attempt to go deeper into your system's jungle.

Leverage

Systems thinking helps create leverage. It is possible due to focused, sustained and an analytical and critical thinking to eradicate underlying issues that adversely affects the performance of the business. Generating leverage is not easy since it includes a considerable amount of risk since both losses and profits are magnified to a large extent. However, systems thinking helps create the probability of leverage by enabling businesses with producing better results that are more positive. When the structure that exists behind a result is considered, it is possible to create the leverage.

Looking at 'The Whole Picture'

If a builders' team is unable to consider a house's structure that is being built by them, it will be an unpardonable mistake. Despite this, several businesses ignore the very structure responsible for their results. This is harmful and detrimental to the business and can eventually result in the loss of the revenue.

A look at the whole picture enables companies to identify the areas where the business is going wrong. They are helped to identify the underlying issues and also other elements that affect the performance of their business. This enables them to optimize the way they work and it will lead to improved results going forward. The emphasis is on the longer term rather than short term.

Those companies that continue with focusing with small pictures are working in a blind manner. Such working style leads to poor habits and ignorance and also creates a negative impact over their employees and peers. Systems thinking focuses on opening the eyes.

Quotes - Systems Thinking

“The eye not only has to see; it has to think.”- Paul Cezanne

“Ultimately, mastering the language of systems thinking also requires the other complementary learning disciplines. Each contributes important principles and tools that make individuals, teams and organizations more able to make the shift from a linear perspective to seeing and acting systematically.” Peter Senge

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SECTION THREE

THE KEY CHALLENGES, PRACTICAL PROBLEMS AND ISSUES LEARNING ORGANIZATIONS FACE

MAIN IDEA

Consider that learning organizations are a base for trial and error methods that allow confronting the problems and facilitate attempts for resolving them. They perform the role of solutions providers.

CRUCIAL ISSUES

- Internal politics
- Problems due to 'Exclusive Power'
- Insufficient time for learning
- Inability to find a proper work-life balance
- Recurring mistakes
- Difficulties faced while leading a learning organization

Overcoming these factors is important for a company. However, several businesses still have not found feasible solutions for these problems and few of them even fail to address these issues. Learning organizations due to their basic nature deliberately evaluate these issues so that their solutions finding process can begin. Learning organizations make us realize that there are problems and even if they are not visible yet, they will eventually surface and learning organizations help us to prepare for that situation.

1. Internal Politics

In a business environment, ego clashes can be high and when people work on a vision that is shared by all, such ego clashes can be detrimental as one person would keep trying to push their vision. Successful organizations are those organizations where a successful idea emerges due to team efforts and not due to individual efforts and the emphasis on knowing who propounded the original idea does not exist.

Remember:

Organization is bigger than everyone

An organization's will comes before anyone else's will

The mindset of individuals must be challenged

People must learn forging common values instead of disjointed values that lead to conflicts.

Organizations can be severely affected due to internal politics and the primary objective of a company must be to work together since disharmony among the employees and their ego clashes will lead to disaster. Individuals are better motivated and work efficiently in an environment that is encouraging and allows for clear communication and debates and promotion of voices of individuals. In the instances when the voices are suppressed, ideas are not heard and this leads to narrow mindedness which is detrimental for the company.

2. Problems due to 'Exclusive Power'

Assigning responsibilities help a person feel worthy. Large number of responsibilities results in better learning and more work. Additionally if people are allowed to make decisions, they feel more motivated to work. Delegation of responsibilities enable employees to feel more worthy and this improves their abilities. Organizations that gives responsibilities to every individual and allow them to make decisions reap higher rewards since it inspired them to work harder.

In a learning organization, there is a focus on localizing the power. Organizations must be careful while assigning responsibilities and delegating powers to them by determining their extent. Managers must continue to exercise control in spite of following a democratic system in the workplace.

3. Insufficient time for learning

Business consumes a large amount of time and several of the businessmen have very little time for socializing and have to quite often compromise and make sacrifices to continue being successful. Since the time is limited, it is pertinent to ask, 'how would such employers manage to find time for creating learning organizations?' and 'how will the employees be able to get the time for learning?'

Though it may sound ruthless, it is imperative that businesses have to make the time if they want to learn. It is more cost efficient to learn, especially in the longer run than to work with ignorance and to nurture habits that are bad and not conducive.

Managers who use learning organizations can afford to claim to be progressive, innovative and forward thinking. They will be able to successfully eliminate those bad habits which were previously responsible for long and short term issues. Managers that fail to find time to learn will be continuously affected by the same problems repeatedly.

The success of a business depends not on what happened earlier but what would happen in future. Adopting the learning organizations allows managers to be prepared for the future and to control the destiny of their company.

4. Inability to find a proper work-life balance

Finding the right work and life balance is difficult for businessmen who have to work hard and for longer hours; resulting in them having no social time. However, a learning organization helps individuals, through personal mastery to not just have a better productivity but also to have a better life outside of their work. It facilitates individuals to be better not just in their work life but also personal life and they can reap the benefits by having a happy and stable workforce. Learning organizations discourage any conflict between social and work life.

Therefore:

Individuals are encouraged to prioritize based on what is more important for them and what place does a thing have in their life's hierarchy.

It encourages spending time with the family and it helps improve all the aspects of the life and these learnings can be used to have a better life at home.

Individuals are encouraged to open up about their personal problems to their organization since family and social issues affect the work

performance. Honest and frank discussion about the life's issues with peers in the organization helps with resolution of the conflicts.

It must be the responsibility of the organizations to help individuals to improve the balance between their social and work life.

5. Recurring mistakes

Everyone makes mistakes, but successful businesses learn from these mistakes. By knowing the cause of the mistake helps avoid them in the future. Learning organizations use the power of Microworld for better accumulation of experiences and it helps eradicate niggling mistakes.

Microworld helps analyze the way we do things and this helps determine how efficient our methods are and if they need replacing.

Microworld offers solutions for short term in a kind of 'slow motion' that can be analyzed for us to examine if such a quick fix is effective or not. Similarly, the long term events are presented as active agencies that demonstrate their beginning and the end results for helping us to determine if they are potent enough.

Microworld helps bring all the business activities under a single system that is unified.

Microworld enables experimenting with our actions. By doing it, we are better placed to test existing as well as new processes and contrast and compare their efficiency.

It encourages critical thinking and analysis of data. It gives managers sufficient time for reflecting.

Due to the nature of Microworld as an experimentation laboratory, inventiveness and creativity are encouraged. Daring and risky ideas are encouraged and it allows them to be tested.

Consider Microworld to be the stage when a movie is edited. It allows addition of things, taking them away and experimenting with them and enables testing them without any specific consequences. Microworld gives

you sufficient time for testing theories before they are applied to the real life situations.

6. Difficulties faced while leading a learning organization

Strong and unique personalities are the traits of leaders. Their charisma, authority and the ability for thinking quickly define them as leaders.

The following qualities must be possessed by the leaders in thinking organization:

- Openness
- Foresight
- Communication skills
- Creativity

Leaders in learning organizations are a guide and friend and have the role of a teacher for those who work with them. They are entrusted with the responsibilities for utilizing the strengths and abilities of the employees and direct the organization for achieving clear objectives, shared vision and common purpose. Leaders must lead as being an example for others to follow and use the above specified 5 disciplines.

Quotes - Section Three

“Systems thinking, personal mastery, mental models, building shared vision and team learning - these might just as well be called the leadership disciplines as the learning disciplines. Those who excel in these areas will be the natural leaders of learning organizations. Ultimately, people follow people who believe in something and have the abilities to achieve results in the service of those beliefs. Or, to put it another way, who are the natural leaders of learning organizations? They are the leaders.” - Peter Senge

CONCLUSION

The Fifth Discipline as a book has rich content that explains the learning organizations' concepts in a deft and simple manner. The manner in which managers must implement their framework and ideas is explained clearly. It acts as a handbook or a guide or even like Bible that aims at eradicating mediocrity and leading the way towards change and progress. The five key disciplines are combined into a single cohesive unit that forms the foundation of the future success of a company and helps create a highly efficient synergy capable of replacing dull business functioning, visions that are short sighted and eliminates mistakes that are repetitive. The book grants access to an exciting, vibrant and new world of business.

Learning organizations' concept is a major breakthrough in the world of business in the last several decades and Peter Senge is the right man for envisaging the concept as well as outlining it. In a composed, cool and a highly absorbing manner, Senge reveals the structural composition of learning organizations and their basic fundamentals and ethos. He is able to do all of it with ease and empowers learners, leaders and the disciples of the concept of systems thinking. Managers who embrace the message given by Senge will do themselves a big favor.

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